# Artificial Intelligence: The Ethical Problems with AI Art

Anneliese S. Little

Department of Computer Science, Charleston Southern University

CSCI 332: Applied Networking

Dr. Yu-Ju Lin

Nov. 30, 2025

**Artificial Intelligence: The Ethical Problems with AI Art**

Artificial Intelligence is a rapidly growing technology that many people continue to grow accustomed to and attached to. AI is a wonderful and useful tool to use if one uses it properly. AI can help with homework questions, studying, and many other things. However, even with the wonders that come with a powerful tool like AI, there are many ethical concerns that come to light as AI gets more advanced. For example, AI became a major problem in the art community. There are several ethical problems that stem from this. Some of those issues include issues determining who the true creator is, plagiarism, theft of both jobs and art itself, lack of consent, and lack of respect. Artificial intelligence is a wonderful thing when used for specific reasons, but AI has no place in the art community.

There are many instances of people using AI to create art. One real life example of this was in 2016. A computer designed a Rembrandt painting called "The Next Rembrandt", and it was created by a 3D printer (UNESCO, 2023). This was accomplished three hundred and fifty-one years after the painter's death (UNESCO, 2023). To do this, the computer analyzed three hundred and forty-six Rembrandt paintings pixel by pixel, and the algorithms upscaled them to create a unique database (UNESCO, 2023). The computer analyzed every detail of Rembrandt's art style, and the 3D printer recreated the same texture of the brushstrokes and layers of paint that Rembrandt used (UNESCO, 2023). However, while this is an amazing feat, it still poses the same problems from earlier.

One of the biggest problems is knowing who the actual creator of the artwork is. There is a strange dichotomy as to how to do this. As UNESCO states, "Who can be designated as the author? The company which orchestrated the project, the engineers, the algorithm, or… Rembrandt himself?" (UNESCO, 2023). UNESCO claims that there needs to be a new definition of what an

“author” is when it comes to AI to properly credit both the original “author” and the algorithms and technologies (UNESCO, 2023). Rembrandt is the owner of the art style, brushstroke techniques, and layers of paint were his, but the algorithm made the image, but the engineers made the technology to do so. Going by what UNESCO says, it seems that all of them should get credit for this masterpiece, but that is not truly fair to Rembrandt.

Another problem is plagiarism. Plagiarism in art is the same as plagiarism in writing, taking an artwork that is not AI’s and making it its own. Chester Avey says that “Most AI tools are trained to recognize and utilize large datasets of images scraped off the Internet, without any mechanisms in place to alert them whether those images themselves are originals or whether they have been used unlawfully” (Avey, 2023). AI is also able to replicate elements, symbols, and typography without crediting the owners properly (Avey, 2023). Even if AI does not completely copy the artwork it references, it can still look extremely similar to the original (Avery, 2023). Of course, AI does not know better, and this is more of a human problem. If someone generates an image and calls it their own, that is a major problem, but if the art is never posted, it is not as severe.

Tying into the previous problem, AI also steals jobs. Not everyone who creates art sells it, but there are many people who do (O’Brien, 2023). Several artists, especially young artists, rely on commissions to save up enough money to do what they need. However, with cheaper or even free AI tools generating commission images, many people are turned away from spending money and helping artists in need (O’Brien, 2023). O’Brien mentions that many people value human art over AI art, but some artists struggle to find that platform and still suffer from lost job opportunities at the hands of AI (O’Brien, 2023). While Rembrandt did not live in a time when AI was rampant, let alone even a concept, it could cause a massive problem for him if he lived in this century. People

could easily use AI to make paintings like Rembrandt's rather than buy his actual paintings. On top of this, there is another issue revolving around AI art.

A fourth problem is lack of consent. Rembrandt died three hundred and fifty-one years before the image was made. Of course, given that he was dead, he had no say in anyone taking his art style and recreating it. A major complaint among the art community about AI art is that AI is trained via data scraping (O'Brien, 2023). O'Brien says that "since AI tools can't generate art out of nothing, that training wasn't passive either. It's not the same as a human learning from Da Vinci by studying his work and trying to paint like him. If anything, it's more like a human tracing the Mona Lisa and then claiming they made it themselves" (O'Brien, 2023). It is the same in this case. Rembrandt's art was basically "traced" by a computer, putting no true effort into creating art, and worst of all, it did this without his permission. Another problem tying into this problem is respect.

Respect is a huge part of the art community. Of course, raw talent plays a role in art, but artists always work hard to become the best they can, and that is one thing that many people admire about artists. O'Brien explains that artists pour their time and energy into creating art, only to be cut up and put back together using AI (O'Brien, 2023). An analogy he uses is someone programming an app that they put their time, energy, passion, heart, and soul into, only to have someone else change the name and a couple of lines of codes and call it their own; that is essentially what AI is doing to the art community (O'Brien, 2023). Unlike in the example though, many artists post their work for free, so they do not even get recognition or compensation for it (O'Brien, 2023). Rembrandt worked extremely hard for years to get to his level of artistry, and the fact that people can take that away by typing in a prompt to get an image that is almost identical to his in no time completely undermines that diligence and passion.

Looking at this case through the lens of virtue ethics, we can see that it does not follow what virtue ethics considers right. This code of ethics gives people a clear picture about what an honest person is. Of course, as its name suggests, it believes in virtues. The Stanford Encyclopedia of Ethics states that "A virtue is an excellent trait of character" and "To possess a virtue is to be a certain sort of person with a certain complex mindset" (Stanford Encyclopedia of Ethics, 2003). It says that the honest person recognizes what a lie is, and that it is a reason why someone should not do something that fulfils that lie (SEoF, 2003). It is important to value honesty with everything and everyone, as well as deplore dishonesty and people who succeed via deception (SEoF, 2003). There is much more that goes into this, but for these arguments, virtues and honesty are enough. Of course, artificial intelligence is not a human being with a complex mindset, so it cannot possess virtues in the way humans can. It also does not care about honesty as it cannot understand that, so it does not mind taking artworks that belong to others and using them to generate its own images. It also has no thought about consent or respect for the artists in question. AI art disagrees with virtue ethics when it comes to the ethical issues that revolve around AI art.

Another way of looking at this case is through a Christian Worldview lens. The problems surrounding AI art certainly do not fit with a Christian Worldview. In Exodus, one of the Ten Commandments states to never steal (Exodus 20:15). Matthew tells Christians the Golden Rule, which is to treat others the way one would want to be treated (Matthew 7:12). AI is a robot, so it does not comprehend rules and virtues like humans do. It does not do anything to try to avoid breaking one of the Ten Commandments as it does not comprehend that. It also has no reason to care what others would do to it or what it does to others. When it comes to issues with AI, it is truly the responsibility of humans to use it ethically because a robot has no morals or virtues.

There are a couple of things people can do to take care of these issues. One option is to hire artists to create art for the algorithm to learn from. If artists are credited, asked for permission, and even paid for it, there may be much less animosity towards AI in the art community. This would solve almost all, if not all, of the ethical problems that AI art present. Another option is to simply cease using AI for art completely. AI can help people who are unable to draw express creative freedom, but there are other solutions to fix this problem. Overall, people should only use AI for art under very specific circumstances, but AI is not something that someone should use.

## References

Avey, C. (2023, December 27). *Ethical Pros and Cons of AI Image Generation*. IEEE Computer Society. https://www.computer.org/publications/tech-news/community-voices/ethics-of-ai-image-generation

O'Brien, S. (2023, November 29). *AiArt: Why Some Artists Are Furious About AI-Produced Art*. IEEE Computer Society. https://www.computer.org/publications/tech-news/trends/artists-mad-at-ai

*New International Version*. (2011). Biblica, Inc. https://www.biblegateway.com/passage/?search=matthew%207&version=NIV

Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy. (2003, July 18). *Virtue Ethics*. https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/ethics-virtue/#Virt

UNESCO. (2023, April 21). *Artificial Intelligence: examples of ethical dilemmas*. https://www.unesco.org/en/artificial-intelligence/recommendation-ethics/cases